

What is available?

Following are the courses that have been released by Microsoft to its training partners across the world.

Course 1905: Building XML-based Web Applications

Description: Training on how to structure and validate data in a document by using document type definitions (DTDs).

Course 1913: Exchanging and Transforming Data Using XML and XSLT

Description: Techniques for exchanging and transforming data using XML and XSLT. Best practices for using XML and XSLT by giving compelling examples of the best ways to solve real-world problems.

sounds cool. Wait, there's more. Some distributed computing systems would be such that each of these three computers could actually be running a different operating system!

To put it in a nutshell, .Net plans to erase the boundaries that exist between applications and the Internet. Instead of interacting with an application or a single Web site, .Net will connect the user to an array of computers and services that will exchange and combine objects and data.

Big deal! What do I get out of it?

Thanks to the unpredictable 'blue screens' and a million other shortcomings that have been an integral part of all its software products, Microsoft has always been criticised. But still, Microsoft products are the obvious choice for new computer users. In fact, most home, SoHo and even enterprise users don't know of any OS other than Windows. Even today, it's virtually impossible for most people to name a word processor other than MS Word. So, in .Net's

known as MCSE, is a networking course wherein a student is imparted training on installing, configuring and administering the Windows 2000 operating system.

On the other hand, the Microsoft Certified Solutions Developer or MSCD is a programming course and deals with developing customised software and solutions for the business or SoHo community. For example, after completing the MSCD course one could use MS SQL or Visual Studio to develop inventory control software for, say, a large production house. After this certification the student can also administer and manage databases with the SQL knowledge that he/she has acquired.

.Net is also a programming course and to a certain extent can be called the successor to MSCD. Till now Microsoft has not announced a replacement for the current MCSD track. However, it might do so in the future. So the best bet for someone who is interested in getting a programming-based certification is to go in for .Net rather than MCSD.

The reason for this is quite simple: if and when Microsoft disbands MCSD, the demand for MCSD professionals is going to decline. In such a scenario, most MCSD professionals will end up spending huge amounts of money and, more importantly, time to upgrade their skills to the .Net platform.



The demand for .Net professionals is going to increase by leaps and bounds once Microsoft releases the first .Net-based operating system

Jitendra Nair

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case as well, people are likely to accept it with open arms.

According to Nua Internet

Surveys, by the end of last year, the number of people connected to the Internet was 407.1 million. To develop software that is stored online for so large a community, a massive number of programmers would be required—something that Microsoft knows it cannot handle by itself. Therefore, it has introduced a certification programme to enable people other than its own employees to use its source code to develop applications for .Net. Once you complete this certification, you will become a certified professional in this platform.

So is MCSE/MCSD Dead?

No it isn't. Microsoft has broadly bifurcated its training and certification into networking, applications and development. The Microsoft Certified Systems Engineer course, popularly

Tools of the trade

As with most certification programmes, there is no fixed minimum requirement that has been laid down for the .Net certification. According to Jitendra Nair, vice president (Software Education Division) of Karrox Technologies, "Though Microsoft hasn't defined any fixed criteria for .Net exams, we at Karrox believe that at the very least the student should be a graduate as it becomes easier for him or her to comprehend the technology that is being imparted."

This isn't all. The .Net platform will be used to develop Web-enabled e-commerce and m-commerce applications, which will incorporate XML as an industry standard interface for exchanging information. So the minimum requirement for taking the exam would be to acquire a thorough knowledge of XML and also of WinForms, C#, ADO.NET and ASP.NET.

It is also recommended that you have knowledge about software servers that facilitate creation of distributed and scalable applications. These include BizTalk Server (for B2B applications), Commerce Server 2000 (for B2C